

Hengst On Hengst Action In Mineral King

When: August 6th to 8th, 2011

Leaders: Matthew Hengst & Adrienne Benedict

Participants: Steve Eckert, Jen Blackie, Elizabeth Hook, Annette Kondo, Jon Vivanti, Anne Kircher, Judith Rigney, Diana Bryant, Rebecca Martin, Gary McCoppin

Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157627270055691/>



With record snowfall in the Sierra this year and the resulting hoards of tiny bloodsucking annoyances (commonly known as mosquitoes) Adrienne Benedict and I set out to lead a trip to Mosquito Lakes out of Mineral King in the hope they were named ironically.

But before we even got to the bloodsuckers we would have to enter via the infamously long and twisting Mineral King road and survive the great furry menace of Mineral King. Evil super marmots.



They might look cute and cuddly but these little guys are infamous for munching through brake lines and drinking antifreeze without the associated dying. They are also sneaky stowaways and in at least one case one hitched a ride all the way back to Orange County.

This has inspired no small amount of writing on the internet including a Facebook group titled “Marmots: Dangerous Creature or Pure Evil???”

(Oddly enough there seems to be a lack in trail cooking ideas involving marmot meat. I see an untapped market.)

But before risking evil fuzzball caused vehicular damage we had the drive to the trailhead.

The Mineral King road is 25 miles of winding 1.5 lane driving with many blind corners. According to the posted signs the drive is supposed to take about 90 minutes to drive and dead ends at Mineral King where there are no gas stations or major commercial facilities.

All of this was so we could hike in and climbing the mighty Hengst peak. Somehow the Sierra Peaks Section had overlooked this finely named mountain when selecting their 200 some Sierra list peaks. Also while we were there we planned to visit some nearby bumps called White Chief and Miner's Nose.

I did the usual late night drive-up with Anne and Jen which meant by the time we hit the winding road it was well after midnight. We also had gas fumes running through the vehicle after a never again to be mentioned mishap at the last gas station which didn't help the poor carsick individual in the back seat.

Still with no traffic I think I did the road in about 60 minutes without getting crazy. (Granted we were all signing along to "I Can't Decide" as we swung around corners...)

<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OFKUnfwBPTU>

After what seemed like an eternity we arrived at the Cold Springs campground. It's one of two campground in Mineral King and Steve Eckert had sent a text earlier letting me know that he and Adrienne had a site there. Being the kind considerate folks we are we stumbled in and woke everyone up in the wee hours of the morning before settling in for a few short hours of sleep.

The next morning we woke at 6 am and everyone was feeling much more chatty.

Day 1: Hike In, Loose Blood, Drink





We had a usually slow wakeup since this trip was in National Park Service land and they require you to pick up the permit in person at the ranger station which doesn't open until 8 am. Rather annoying since the usual after hour's pickup that USFS conveys all the same information.



A quick and pointless stop at the ranger station later and we were off to the Farewell Gap trailhead.

I'd been assured by multiple rangers multiple times that the little fuzzy terrors had settled down for the season so none of our vehicles would be using protection. Others in the parking lot hadn't gotten the same memo.



Here you have someone attempting the classic chicken wire barrier method. The ranger I spoke too when I originally planned the trip stated this is what she used but that it took her quite a bit of time every day to make it effective.

Her recommendation was the burrito method. This involves driving onto a tarp and wrapping the vehicle using ropes



Steve shared stories of this method failing when the marmots got on top and squirmed under the tarp or just chewed their way through.

We just parked and trusted the ranger lady.

This was a student trip and we were planning to go in with a large group. Soon we had everyone except for the one pair who slept down in Visalia but managed to arrive just as I was getting ready to leave them. We shouldered our packs and set off.



Our trail was the main path up towards Farwell Gap



We ran into several other groups along the way including one complete with ropes and climbing gear who were headed for a cave located somewhere further in the backcountry.



Our trail split off towards Eagle and Mosquito Lakes and after that there was hardly any traffic other than a few people reporting epic mosquito levels at the lakes above.



We did come across this rather odd sinkhole though. Water was flowing in and disappearing but no one wanted to jump in and explore.



Me with Team Pigtails.



Women are rather violent aren't they?



We soon reached the lowest of the Mosquito Lakes and our hopes that they were named ironically died a quick death.

(Adrienne had a map from a previous trip here years ago and it actually has a smashed mosquito on it. Fitting. Also as the only person who had been there before she came equipped with a full mosquito suit.)



From here the trail became more of a use trail with occasional bits of cross country as we gained altitude and passed several lakes.



At one point a few of us made it to a lake a bit ahead of the rest of the pack and took the opportunity to strip down and jump in.



Well, some of us stripped down.

<Pictures of a soaking wet underwear clad Hengst excluded out of a sense of common decency>



Lake 3 had a nice camp spot but had two main things against it. First Adrienne had camped here years ago and I hate doing repeats. Second there was another tent visible and I get downright anti social in the backcountry. We continued on up the drainage.



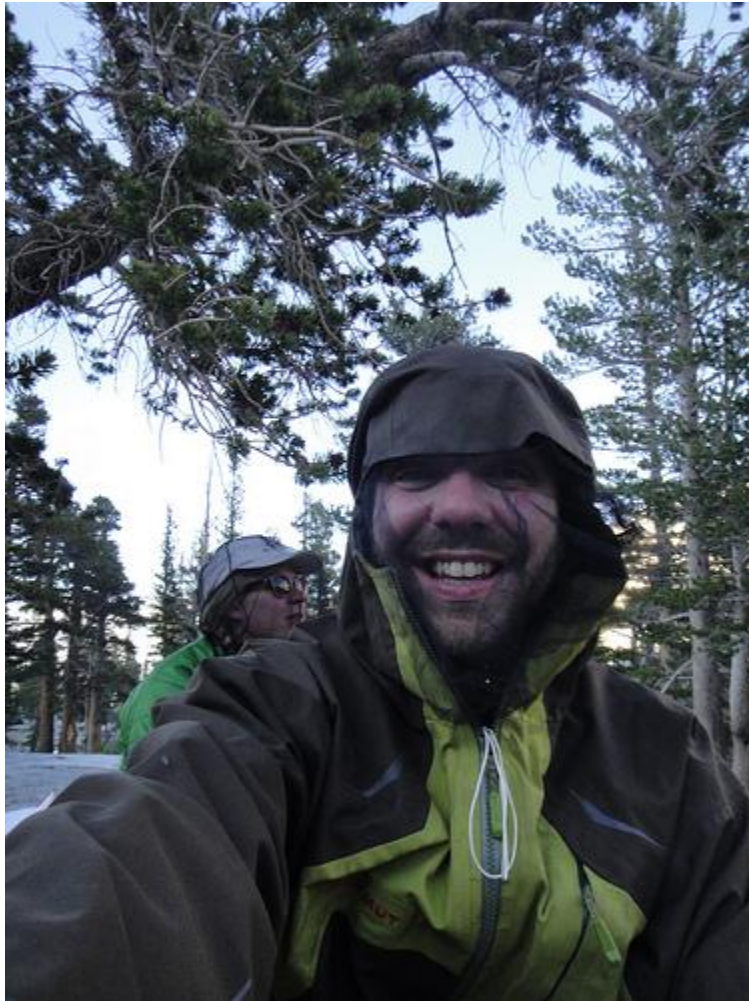
It got a bit rougher here with some bushwhacking followed by an easy slab.



We reached lake 4 and found some decent but not spectacular sites. Jen and I ran ahead to the upper lake but found snow melt had soaked the obvious camp spots. We settled on the second highest lake and set up camp.



Sadly there were still mosquitoes. Lots of mosquitoes. So many they formed a sort of cloud in the air above the lake.



Bug nets were our friend with some of us taking it to greater extremes than others...



Having established camp and covered ourselves in netting and poison it was time for the traditional happy hour feast!

My contribution was appropriately green.



Green Chartreuse (110 proof or 55%) is a naturally green liqueur flavored with extracts from 132 plants with its coloring coming from chlorophyll. (Think herbal Jägermeister)

Interesting note when I bought it at a state liquor store in Idaho the clerk's reaction was "That stuff? Why in the hell would you want that?"

A few people may agree with his assessment.





We had a decent enough night.

Day 2: Summit and Swim Day

We awoke the next morning and enjoyed the short period where there is light but it's still too cold for the mosquitoes to eat you alive.



We had a peak to climb but it was an easy one so we could spend a somewhat leisurely breakfast in camp.

Miss Anne, experimental trail baker extraordinaire, had decided to try steam baked muffins this trip. For Science!





It worked out pretty well. Other than being slightly pale they were quite yummy.

Breakfast over and mosquitoes descending we sprayed on our DEET and headed out.



The approach was rather straightforward. We headed up the slopes past the upper lake towards a visible notch. We needed to keep things to second class and student friendly but I didn't think that would be too much of a worry.







There were one or two spots where we had to watch our footing but overall the climb wasn't bad.



Hengst is the manly protrusion to the right.

Once up top the terrain became easier if somewhat less interesting but at least we were finally beyond the mosquitoes.



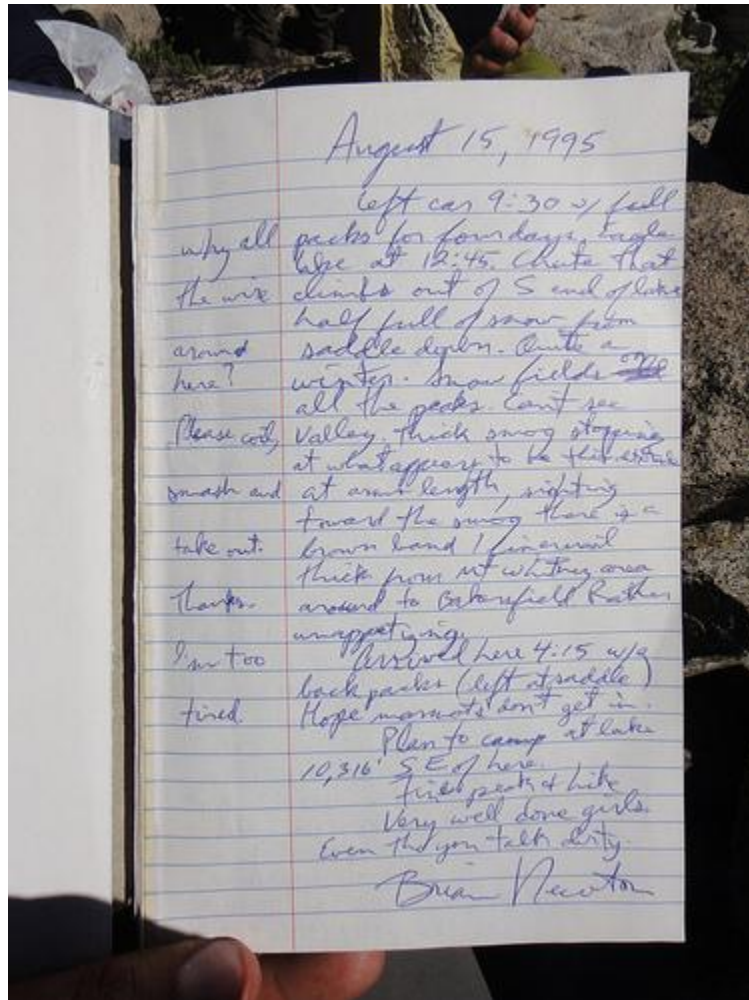
We strolled along the ridge towards the summit of Hengst.



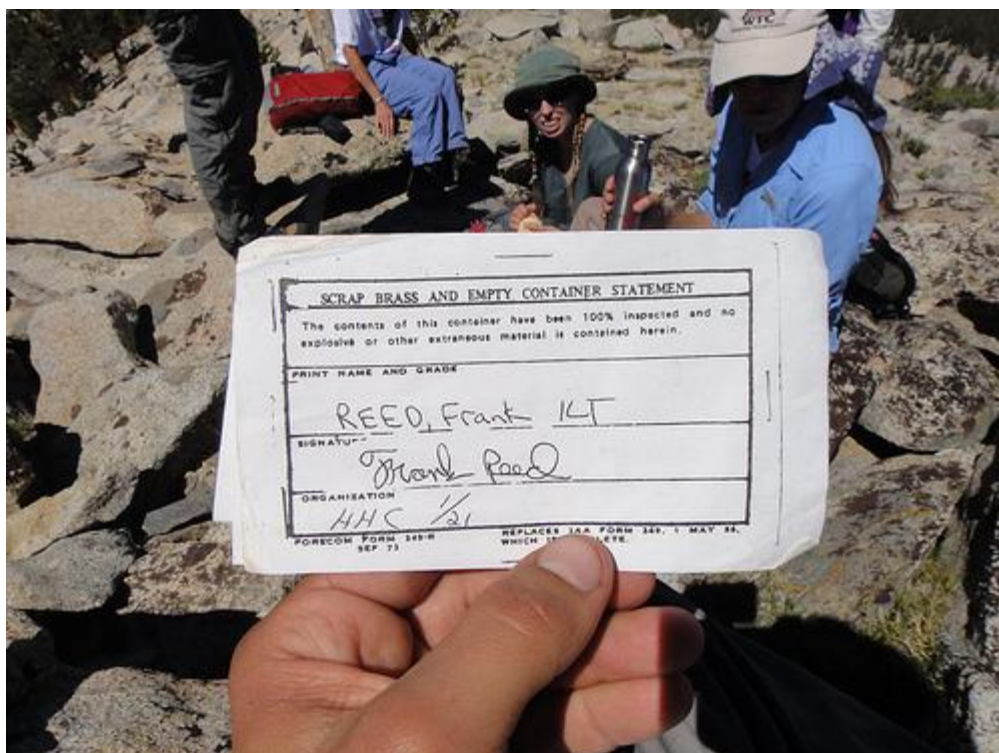
It was an easy second class walk up.



From the top we could look down at Mosquito Lakes. We're camped at the second highest lake. You can't see the mosquitos from up here...



Sadly I was only the second Matthew Hengst to have summited Hengst. Damn you Alice Hengst and family!



Well that's a relief... (I've never seen one of these before)



Team Pigtails poses for a victory shot.



And the rest of our motley lot.



Just the OC WTC students.



A view over towards the Kaweah's that Jen and I would be visiting a few weeks later.



Next up was White Chief which was located the opposite direction along the ridge.



We backtracked our steps and continued on.





A small lake behind White Chief.



Aaaaaand...yea...that was it. I'm assuming it's a more impressive peak when viewed from below. We signed in and headed for camp remarking in how it wasn't near as awesome as Hengst.



The down climb back to camp was uneventful.



We made it back with plenty of daylight to spare. And a lake sitting right there.

Environment destroying swim time!

It turns out that the cool water actually imparted immunity to mosquitoes for about 10 minutes after you came out after which you needed to dive back in again.



The warm sun made this not overly unpleasant once you got past the initial cold plunge and soon all but three of us were in the water.



Once the sun started to go down we all climbed out and put on our dry layer to enjoy a rather mosquito infected happy hour. Adrienne seemed quite happy inside her bug proof suit.



Some of us just made due.

Somewhere during the evening we picked up a 8 year (-ish) old girl who was apparently camped down slope with her parents. She informed us that her family came up here all the time and that we were occupying her favorite spot but that it was ok because they had another one.

She was also aghast that we were using liberal applications of DEET to keep the mosquitoes to a manageable level. She informed us that was horrible and that her family had a much better solution. Jen later escorted her back to camp and found out what they were using...25% DEET.

Day 3: And Out



We had another relax wakeup and packed up early enough the mosquitoes weren't a horrible menace.





Retreating down the drainage was easier than climbing it though with one slower member a good chunk of us ended up having to spend some bonus time standing around in heavily mosquito infested brush.



Jen's hat in particular seemed to be the site of a rather vigorous mosquito orgy possibly helped by her refusal to use DEET.



Climbing out of the Mosquito Lakes drainage we dropped packs and after a short lunch headed out to the point marked Miner's Nose on the topo.



Yes that is the summit.



There was a rather nice view of the canyon below though including our vehicles.

Returning to the trail we continued down taking periodic breaks to gather the group together.



Steve impresses us with his hair styling technique during a short break.



And soon we were back down to the trailhead.





Proof everyone was in one piece and at least on relatively good terms.

Driving down the windy Mineral King Road the entire caravan had an encounter with a rather unpleasant woman driving a convertible down the center of the road gesturing angrily at all of us for daring to drive in our lane.



Most of us stopped at a fairly decent Mexican food restaurant down the canyon at Three Rivers before starting the long drive home.